REFERENCE REPORT

Shiro Kuramata

1934–1991. The Japanese designer who spent thirty years trying to make furniture weigh nothing.

Shiro Kuramata is the rare designer whose best pieces are instantly recognisable and still hard to explain. A chair made of six sheets of glass and nothing else. An armchair of nickel-plated steel mesh that reads as a drawing of a chair rather than a chair. A block of clear acrylic with red paper roses frozen inside it. He worked in Tokyo for his entire career, built most of his reputation through interiors that were torn down within a few years, and was dead at 56. Yet he is one of a handful of Japanese designers with a secure place in the Western canon, collected by MoMA, the Met and the Vitra Design Museum, and the subject of a 600-piece Phaidon monograph.

This report is a primer: who he was, what he was trying to do, the dozen pieces you should know, and the lenses from his work that are worth stealing. A short list of sources is at the end.

Why he matters

- **He treated materials as the idea.** Acrylic, glass, expanded steel mesh and terrazzo were not finishes applied to a form. Each piece asks what a chair or a cabinet becomes when it is made from one industrial material and nothing else.
- **He pursued weightlessness and transparency as a lifelong theme.** Gravity was something to escape. His pieces try to float, dissolve, or exist as outlines.
- **He bridged Japanese minimalism and Italian postmodernism.** A founding member of Memphis in 1981, he brought restraint to a movement known for noise, and brought colour and play back to Tokyo.
- **He designed from memory and dreams, not from function.** He kept dream journals, named chairs after jazz standards and film characters, and said openly that he was interested in furniture that is not meant to be used.
- **His influence is quiet but everywhere.** Cantilevered shelves with folded clothes in a fashion boutique, cast resin with objects suspended inside, mesh furniture, and the idea that a shop interior can be an artwork all trace back to him.

Life in brief

1934	Born 29 November in Tokyo. Grows up through the war and the occupation; the shortage years shape a lasting fascination with new, abundant industrial materials.
1953	Finishes a woodworking course at Tokyo Metropolitan Polytechnic High School.

1954–56	Studies interior design at the Kuwasawa Design Institute, then the most progressive design school in Japan.
1957–63	Works in the display and interior departments of Tokyo department stores, including San-Ai in Ginza. Builds a practice of making retail spaces feel like something more than shops.
1965	Opens Kuramata Design Office in Tokyo. Begins the acrylic experiments that define his early work.
1970	*Furniture in Irregular Forms, Side 1 and Side 2*: the wavy plywood chests that first bring him international attention.
1972	Mainichi Industrial Design Award.
1976	*Glass Chair*. Begins designing boutiques for Issey Miyake, a collaboration that will run for the rest of his life.
1981	Invited by Ettore Sottsass to be a founding member of Memphis in Milan. Receives the Japan Cultural Design Prize.
1986	*How High the Moon*, later put into production by Vitra.
1988	*Miss Blanche*. Opens a second studio in Paris. Kiyotomo sushi bar, Tokyo.
1990	Made a Chevalier of the Ordre des Arts et des Lettres by the French Ministry of Culture.
1991	Dies 1 February in Tokyo of heart failure caused by myocarditis, aged 56.

The ideas

Weightlessness. Kuramata said he wanted to be free of gravity, and almost every mature piece is an attempt at it. The *Glass Chair* has no visible structure. *How High the Moon* keeps the silhouette of a plump club chair but replaces all its mass with a mesh you can see through. *Miss Blanche* holds flowers mid-air. He also hated seams, reportedly calling them the hardest part of any object because they reveal that the thing is finite.

Transparency and immateriality. Acrylic in the 1960s and 70s, glass in the mid-70s, expanded metal from the mid-80s. Each is a material that lets light and space pass through. The goal was never a clear chair for its own sake; it was an object that reads as an outline of itself, an apparition in the room rather than a presence.

Memory and dreams. He kept dream journals and sketchbooks, one titled *Words, Dreams, Memories*. Childhood smells, the sound of a record, a line from a play were his raw material. Many works are named after jazz standards (*How High the Moon*, *Sing Sing Sing*, *Begin the Beguine*, *Apple Honey*, *Twilight Time*) or after records themselves (*Side 1*, *Side 2*). *Miss Blanche* is named for Blanche DuBois in *A Streetcar Named Desire*.

Function as a side effect. Everything he made works. The 49-drawer cabinet opens, the glass chair holds roughly 100 kilograms, the seven-handed clock tells time. But function was not the starting point. He described furniture that simply happens to manifest as furniture, and most of his drawer pieces were made without a client.

> *“I am interested in furniture that is not intended to be used, but simply happens to manifest as furniture.”*
>
> Shiro Kuramata, quoted in the 2023 Setagaya Art Museum retrospective

> *“Memories, including the dream experiences I had, for me, constitute an infinite cosmos.”*
>
> Shiro Kuramata, from his notebooks

> *“Blanche DuBois herself is fake.”*
>
> Kuramata, on why the roses in Miss Blanche had to be artificial

Key works

Fourteen pieces that cover the whole arc, from acrylic experiments to the late resin work.

Year	Work	Material	Why it matters
1968	**Pyramid**	Clear acrylic, revolving drawers	Early acrylic cabinet; a stack of transparent drawers on a central pivot. The first appearance of the transparent storage idea.
1969	**Luminous Chair**	White acrylic, internal light	A chair that is also a lamp. Shows the ambition to make an object glow rather than sit.
1970	**Furniture in Irregular Forms, Side 1 and Side 2**	Lacquered plywood	Tall chests of drawers that undulate like a wave. The piece that made his name abroad. Side 1 reissued by Cappellini from 1986.
1970	**Revolving Cabinet**	Acrylic drawers on a steel spine	Twenty drawers that fan out around a pole. Still in production with Cappellini.
1972	**Oba-Q lamp**	Thermoformed acrylic	A draped, ghost-shaped light named after the manga ghost Obake no Q-taro. Humour enters the work.
1976	**Glass Chair**	Six panes of glass, UV-cured adhesive	No frame, no fixings; the panes are bonded with a then-new photo-bond glue so the joints vanish. His answer to the furniture he found disappointing in 2001: A Space Odyssey.
1981	**Imperial cabinet**	Lacquered wood, Memphis	His contribution to the first Memphis collection. Calm and vertical next to the Milanese noise.
1983	**Kyoto table**	Star Piece terrazzo, steel	Terrazzo with shards of coloured glass set in concrete, a material he called Star Piece and reused for years. Produced by Memphis.
1985	**Begin the Beguine**	Bentwood chair burned, then cast in steel mesh	An homage to Josef Hoffmann. A Thonet-style chair is set on fire and its form rebuilt in mesh, a ghost of a chair.
1985	**Sing Sing Sing**	Expanded steel mesh	First of the mesh chairs, made for XO in France. Lightweight and see-through, a sketch in metal.

Year	Work	Material	Why it matters
1985	**Twilight Time**	Stepped glass top, three mesh cones	Table with a layered glass top on cone legs. Glass and mesh, the two transparencies, in one piece.
1986	**How High the Moon**	Nickel-plated expanded steel mesh	His most famous chair. A generous armchair silhouette with all its weight removed. Produced by Vitra from 1987.
1988	**Miss Blanche**	Cast acrylic resin, artificial roses, aluminium legs	Paper roses poured into clear resin so they float in the seat. Roughly 70 kg, and the most valuable piece of post-war Japanese design at auction.
1990	**Acrylic Stool with Feathers**	Cast acrylic, feathers	The last of the resin pieces: feathers suspended as if falling, finished a few months before his death.

Interiors: the work that disappeared

Most of Kuramata's income and much of his reputation came from interiors: bars, restaurants, clubs and shops in Tokyo and later abroad. Almost none survive. He knew they were temporary and designed them that way. Three stand out.

- **Issey Miyake boutiques (1976 onward).** He designed dozens of Miyake shops, from Tokyo to Bergdorf Goodman in New York (1984) and Paris. His innovation was to lay garments flat on thin cantilevered shelves rather than hang them, so the clothes read as objects and the shop as a gallery.
- **Kiyotomo sushi bar, Shinbashi, Tokyo (1988).** A small sushi restaurant with a curved ceiling and a long counter, among his most complete surviving rooms. It was bought in its entirety, dismantled and is now reassembled inside M+ in Hong Kong, where you can walk into it.
- **Oblomov bar, Il Palazzo, Fukuoka (1989).** Commissioned by Aldo Rossi for his hotel. One of a few Kuramata interiors still intact in Japan.

Memphis and Sottsass

Kuramata met Ettore Sottsass in the 1970s and the two became close. When Sottsass launched Memphis in Milan in 1981 he invited Kuramata as a founding member, the only Japanese designer in the group. Kuramata's Memphis pieces (*Imperial*, *Kyoto*, *Sally*) share the movement's appetite for colour and surprising material but keep his stillness. The exchange ran both ways. Memphis gave him an international stage and the permission to be playful; his restraint gave Memphis one of its few quiet voices. The 21_21 Design Sight exhibition in Tokyo in 2010 was devoted to the pair.

Where to see him

- **Collections:** Museum of Modern Art and the Metropolitan Museum, New York; SFMOMA; Museum of Fine Arts, Boston; Philadelphia Museum of Art; Museum of Arts and Design, New York; Vitra Design Museum, Weil am Rhein; Hara Museum, Tokyo; M+, Hong Kong (Kiyotomo).

- **Retrospectives:** Hara Museum, Tokyo (1996); SFMOMA (1997); 21_21 Design Sight, Tokyo, with Sottsass (2010); *The Work of Shiro Kuramata: A Microcosmos of Memory*, Setagaya Art Museum, Tokyo, then Toyama and the National Museum of Modern Art, Kyoto (November 2023 to August 2024). The 2023 show was the first Tokyo solo exhibition in over twenty years and included his dream journals.
- **In production:** Vitra (*How High the Moon*), Cappellini (*Side 1*, *Side 2*, *Revolving Cabinet*, *Pyramid*), Glas Italia (*Glass Chair* and table reissues), XO (*Sing Sing Sing*). Ishimaru in Tokyo cast the original resin pieces.
- **At auction:** a *Miss Blanche* sold at Christie's London in October 2007 for £156,500, about three times its high estimate. Editions continue to appear at Phillips and Christie's.

Lenses worth stealing

Ways of looking from Kuramata that transfer to any product or space.

- **Pick one material and push it to its limit.** The Glass Chair is only glass. Mesh chairs are only mesh. The constraint is the concept.
- **Keep the familiar silhouette, remove the mass.** *How High the Moon* works because it is recognisably an armchair. The surprise is in what is missing, not in a new shape.
- **Hide the seams.** A joint that disappears changes how an object feels. Invest in the adhesive, the weld, the tolerance.
- **Name things after feelings.** A jazz standard or a film character gives an object a mood before anyone touches it.
- **Let display be the design.** The Miyake shelves prove a store fixture can define a brand more than the architecture around it.
- **Suspend something fragile in something permanent.** Roses in resin, feathers in acrylic. Contrast of the ephemeral and the fixed is a reliable source of emotion.
- **Design from a dream journal.** Keep one. His best ideas came from memory, not from a brief.

Read and watch

- Deyan Sudjic, *Shiro Kuramata* (Phaidon, 2013). Two volumes in an acrylic slipcase: a biography and a catalogue of all 600-plus works. The definitive reference.
- *Shiro Kuramata 1934–1991*, Hara Museum of Contemporary Art exhibition catalogue (1996).
- *The Work of Shiro Kuramata: A Microcosmos of Memory*, Setagaya Art Museum catalogue (2023), which reproduces his dream journals and texts.
- Vitra Design Museum and M+ online collection pages for object-level detail and photographs.
- Ted Loos, “Shiro Kuramata,” *Introspective* (1stdibs), an accessible profile built around an interview with Sudjic.

Sources used for this report

- Wikipedia, Shiro Kuramata: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Shiro_Kuramata
- Wallpaper*, Shiro Kuramata's multilayered cosmos on view in Tokyo: https://wallpaper.com/design-interiors/shiro-kuramata-exhibition
- Friedman Benda, The Work of Shiro Kuramata: A Microcosmos of Memory: https://www.friedmanbenda.com/exhibitions/the-work-of-shiro-kuramata-a-microcosmos-of-memory/
- 1stdibs Introspective, Shiro Kuramata: https://www.1stdibs.com/introspective-magazine/shiro-kuramata
- Tokyo Art Beat, Liberated Materials: Clearly Kuramata: https://www.tokyoartbeat.com/en/articles/-/liberated-materials-clearly-kuramata
- Phillips, artist page: https://phillips.com/artist/8986/shiro-kuramata
- Phaidon, Shiro Kuramata by Deyan Sudjic (2013), publisher listings.

A note on reliability. Dates for the early acrylic pieces (Pyramid, Luminous Chair) and some interiors vary by a year between sources. Where sources disagreed I used the Phaidon catalogue dates as cited by museums and auction houses.